The First Sunday of Advent

Isaiah 64:1-9 * Psalm 80:1-7, 17-19
1 Corinthians 1:3-9 * Mark 13:24-37

Prayer

Gracious God, as we begin this Advent season,
help us to slow down and watch for your presence.
Jesus reminds us to stay awake, to be alert,
and to live with expectation. Open our hearts to see you at work—
in our lives, in our community, and in the world around us.
Give us the patience to wait, the faith to trust,
and the courage to remain faithful while we await Christ's coming.
As we study your Word together, speak to us and prepare our hearts for the hope, peace, joy, and love of Jesus.
In Christ's name we pray,
Amen.

Opening

1. When you hear the word "Advent," what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What is something you find difficult about waiting?
3. Have you ever waited for something that you were really excited about? What made the waiting difficult—or worthwhile?

Engaging the Text

1. In verse 26, how is the Son of Man described when He comes? How does this contrast with Jesus' first coming as a humble baby?]

2. Look at verses 28-29. What lesson does Jesus want the disciples to learn from the fig tree?

3. Why do you think Jesus emphasizes the command to **"keep watch"** or **"stay awake"** four different times in this short passage (verses 33, 34, 35, 37)?

4. In verse 34, Jesus notes that the master leaves his servants "each with their assigned task." What do you feel God has assigned or called *you* to do while we wait for His return?

5. How does the certainty of Jesus' return bring you comfort? Conversely, how does it challenge the way you spend your time, money, or relationships?

6. Imagine a friend asks you, "If Jesus could return at any moment, how should that change my day-to-day routine tomorrow?" Based on this passage, how would you answer them?

Application Activity

The "Stay Awake" Alarm (Micro-Habit Challenge)

Since Jesus emphasizes staying awake and keeping watch, challenge the group to create a physical reminder for the upcoming week. Have everyone take out their phones and set a random recurring daily alarm.

The Prompt: "Whenever this alarm goes off this week, it's your 'Stay Awake' signal. Take 30 seconds to pause whatever you are doing, acknowledge God's presence, and pray a simple prayer: 'Lord, keep me alert to your work today, and ready for your return.'"